STAYMAN CONVENTION

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

STAYMAN CONVENTION SUMMARY

When one partner opens 1NT it is difficult to uncover a 4-4 Major fit using only natural bidding. The Stayman Convention solves the problem and improves bidding accuracy as well. As an additional benefit, when you use Stayman the 1NT Opener usually becomes the Declarer on the hand, thereby keeping the stronger hand concealed.

The Stayman Convention is worthwhile even if it is the only convention you use. However, there are added benefits to using Stayman in conjunction with Jacoby Transfers. The two work smoothly together with Stayman taking care of those hands where Responder has a 4-card Major(s) and Jacoby Transfers taking care of those hands where Responder has a 5- or 6-card Major.

The actual working of Stayman is simple:
Following a 1NT opening, Responder will only use Stayman when he holds at least one 4-card Major suit.
He does so by bidding 2♣ which requires Opener to reply as follows:

- With no 4-card Major suit he bids 2♦.
- With a 4-card ♥ suit, (and possibly 4 ♠s as well), he bids 2♥.
- With a 4-card ♠ suit, (but not 4 ♥s), he bids 2♠.

It really is as simple as that. Well, almost.

Stayman takes much of the guesswork (sometimes called judgement) out of the bidding and steers you directly to these two goals:

1. With a partnership 26 points you will reach game, with 33 you will reach slam.
2. With a partnership 8+ cards in a Major suit you will play in that suit, otherwise you will play notrump.

For the first point consider this table which is based on the 1NT opener holding 15-17 points.

Resp Points	Opener Points			Bidding Target
	15	16	17	
8	23	24	25	Partscore
9	24	25	26	
10	25	26	27	
11	26	27	28	
12	27	28	29	Game
13	28	29	30	
14	29	30	31	
15	30	31	32	
16	31	32	33	
17	32	33	34	Slam
18	33	34	35	

Responder's actions are as follows:

- 8 points or fewer - usually pass, but may use Stayman and then pass
- 9 points - invite partner to game
- 10 points - either invite or force to game, using your judgement
- 11-15 points - force to game
- 16 points - invite to slam
- 17 points - either invite or force to slam, using your judgement
- 18 points or more - force to slam

Opener's actions are as follows:

- 15 points - decline invitations
- 16 points - either decline or accept, using your judgement
- 17 points - accept invitations

As to the second point above (the 8-card trump fit) Responder is usually in charge.

- If Opener shows a 4-card Major which matches one held by Responder, then Responder picks that suit.
- If Opener does not show a 4-card Major which matches one held by Responder, then Responder picks notrump.

Opener usually has no say in the suit selection, with this important exception:
If Opener holds 4 cards in **EACH** Major suit he responds 2♥.
Should Responder then bid notrump, indicating a dislike for ♥s, Opener should bid ♠s because she knows there is a 4-4 ♠ fit,

Some comments are in order about the point count methods used on these pages.
Initial point count for both hands is based on 4-3-2-1 plus one point for a fifth card in a suit.
Revalued points (only after a trump fit is discovered) are +1 for a doubleton, +2 for a singleton and +3 for a void. Both hands should count these revalued short-suit points; Opener of course would not have a singleton or void.

One more point. Stayman should definitely be used after 2NT openings as well.

25 examples will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦10

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥7

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 2♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣K

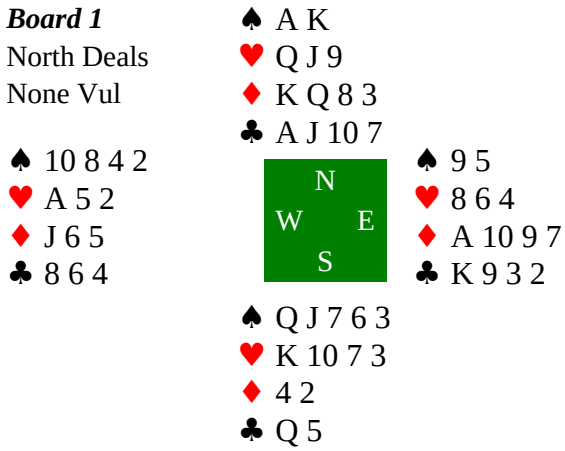
Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥7

Board: 6
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠3

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul



West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♦	Pass	3♠
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♦10

With a balanced 20 points you open 2NT and partner responds 3♣.

Stayman applies after a 2NT opening, just one level higher. With no 4-card Major you bid 3♦. Partner next bids 3♠.

Partner is showing 5 ♠s and 4 ♥s. In neither case would you have the 8-card fit you need. So you bid 3NT.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 8
♥ 10 7 4 3
♦ 10 6 4 3 2
♣ 8 6 5

♠ Q 9 6 3
♥ K 5
♦ Q 8 7 5
♣ 7 4 2



♠ K J 10 5
♥ A Q J 9
♦ A J 9
♣ K Q

♠ A 7 4 2
♥ 8 6 2
♦ K
♣ A J 10 9 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3♣	Pass	3♥	Pass
3NT	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♦K

You open 2NT and partner responds 3♣.

With 4 cards in each Major suit you bid 3♥. Partner puts you in 3NT. What do you do? Pass or bid?

You certainly do not pass. Partner's Stayman bid tells you he has a 4-card Major suit. His 3NT bid tells you the suit was not ♥s. Elementary, Watson, the suit must be ♠s. So you convert the 3NT bid to 4♠.

If you want to make yourself happy you use Stayman, just imagine playing 3NT after a ♣ lead!

Board 3
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K Q 4 2 ♥ A Q 10 9 4 3 ♦ — ♣ 8 7 4	
♠ 10 9 6 ♥ 7 2 ♦ 6 5 4 3 2 ♣ 10 5 2		♠ 7 3 ♥ 8 6 5 ♦ Q J 10 9 7 ♣ A Q 3
	♠ A J 8 5 ♥ K J ♦ A K 8 ♣ K J 9 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♠
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

6♠ by South
Lead: ♥7

South opens 2NT.

Wow! Start thinking slam, but first things first. Find the suit by starting with Stayman. You bid 3♣ and partner replies 3♠. What do you say next?

Your hand revalues to 16 points now that you know there's a ♠ fit. So certainly you want to be in slam as long as there are not two quick ♣ losers. At this point you might try something like a 4♦ cue bid, hoping partner will read that as a slam try in ♠s, but denying the ♣ control. But that seems awfully easy to be misunderstood. We suggest an immediate 6♠.

Good thing it's being played by South, right?

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

♠ K 9 6
♥ 7 5 2
♦ 10 4
♣ A K 10 5 3

♠ A 8 3
♥ A K 6 4
♦ Q 5 2
♣ Q 8 7



♠ Q 7 4 2
♥ 10 9 8 3
♦ J 8 7 6 3
♣ —

♠ J 10 5
♥ Q J
♦ A K 9
♣ J 9 6 4 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♥			
All Pass			

2♥ by West
Lead: ♣K

West opens 1NT.

Your first thought should be that with only 4 points you will pass. But on second thought, what would partner respond if you bid a Stayman 2♣? So you give it a shot and partner says 2♥. What next?

What's next is your PASS. And if he had bid 2♠ you also would have passed. And if he had bid 2♦ you also would have passed. You figured that with this hand any response partner could make would be a better place than 1NT.

Board 5
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A K 7 3
♥ A 9 5
♦ 9 8 2
♣ A Q 2

♠ 10 9 6
♥ J 2
♦ K 5 4
♣ J 9 7 5 4



♠ 4 2
♥ Q 10 8 7 3
♦ A 10 6 3
♣ 6 3

♠ Q J 8 5
♥ K 6 4
♦ Q J 7
♣ K 10 8

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥7

North opens 1NT.

With 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit this fits the model for Stayman.

But thinking a little further, with this 4-3-3-3 distribution you have no ruffing values whatsoever. So even if partner also has 4 ♠s there might not be an advantage in playing the suit contract. So for this specific distribution you ignore your 4-card Major and just bid 3NT.

Board 6
North Deals
E-W Vul

♠ K J 7 5 4 2
♥ A 10 2
♦ 4 3
♣ Q J

♠ A Q 10 6
♥ Q 7
♦ 10 9 5
♣ K 9 7 4



♠ 9 8
♥ K J 4
♦ A Q J 7
♣ A 10 8 5

♠ 3
♥ 9 8 6 5 3
♦ K 8 6 2
♣ 6 3 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	Pass	1NT	Pass
2♣	2♠	Pass	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠3

After you open 1NT partner bids 2♣, then North says 2♠. What do you say next?

Basically you said your say when you opened 1NT. You don't have a 4-card Major and you have a minimum hand. The best way to convey this information to partner is to pass. At which point partner jumps to 3NT.

Pass, then "Thank you partner" when dummy comes down. The thing to remember is that partner is in charge. You describe your hand as well as you can and then sit back and let him make the decisions. Perhaps you would have doubled if you held his hand but he didn't.